

Great Dissertations

These dissertations are provided here as examples of good work completed as part of study leading to the MA Leading Innovation and Change or the MBAs that succeeded MALIC. These were all judged to be high quality pieces of work (they all received 70% or more). The authors have given us permission to show them to participants on these programmes who are beginning to undertake the dissertation.

The dissertations demonstrate both a range of topics and a range of methodologies, but there is still much scope for you to tackle different topics and use different methodologies.

Note: the dissertations completed in 2012 were assessed using a slightly different marking scheme from that which applies in 2013 and onwards. In the 2013+ scheme, 10% of the marks are awarded for reflections on the dissertation process.

Sue Arundale 2012 Value creation in non-profit member organisations: Building the membership base and improving the brand through social media

Aims to discover whether a non-profit member organisation can create sufficient value for its members to sustain membership as its key revenue generator: in particular to explore whether social media – ie social networking sites and user-generated information sites - had replaced what the organisation was offering members. The study found that the organisation could potentially create value for members, and that – far from replacing the organisation's services - social media presented an unexploited opportunity to increase value.

Method: survey, followed by semi-structured interviews with a sample of survey respondents.

Grade: Distinction

Marcela Binova 2013 Exploring innovation practices amongst licensed microfinance institutions in Cambodia

This is a study of innovation practices amongst licensed microfinance institutions (MFIs) in Cambodia. It explores the innovation-related practices and behaviours of executives in these institutions. The research found that product innovation dominates, but other innovations are also perceived as important, including delivery channel, strategy and customer-facing processes. The MFIs used a wide range of methods to obtain and develop innovation ideas from staff and customers; innovation processes were largely informal.

Method: semi-structured interviews with 10 executives of MFIs.

Grade: Distinction

Reda Mohamed Helal 2012 The relationship between leadership styles and a change process in a third party processor: A study of Processing International.

The research aims to assess the relationship between leadership styles of senior managers in a case study organisation that was undergoing a change process, and the satisfaction of their staff. Participative and delegative styles were associated with higher levels of job satisfaction than an autocratic style.

Method: questionnaires gathered from 11 senior managers in the case organisation, and 76 employees.

Grade: Distinction

Steven Janes 2015 Exploring resistance to change: case study of a German sporting-goods company

This dissertation studies the phenomenon of resistance to change within a case study organisation, considering a particular change and asking “What caused resistance to the organisational change within the case study company, how did management respond, and how effective were their responses?” The research found a clear association between resistant behaviour and: participation and communication; stake and vested interest; and the credibility of the solution. The dissertation proposes a model to help predict resistant attitudes, which indicates how these attitudes might translate into resistant behaviour.

Methods: semi-structured interviews with 12 key stakeholders, plus documents including in-house surveys, contemporary management presentations, created during the period of the change.

Grade: Distinction

Carine Jonckheere 2014 Effective humanitarian leadership in Sudan: Beyond conventional paths, behaviours and competencies

The research seeks to identify the leadership competencies and skills required to lead an effective relief intervention in Sudan. It finds that effective leaders in this situation in Sudan are systemic thinkers deeply embedded in their context, who can creatively and gradually transcend barriers and constraints. Their credibility is built on extensive knowledge and cognitive capabilities, and is expressed through a behavioural flexibility that enables the management of multifaceted tensions.

Method: depth interviews with 14 respondents, plus analysis of documents (reports, minutes of meetings etc).

Grade: Distinction

Mats Kallmyr 2017 Transactional vs Transformational Leadership: How Do Leaders Support Innovation and Change

This research reviewed the connection between change and innovation, and aimed to understand how transactional and transformational leaders influence and lead organizational innovation and change. It found that transformational leadership that emphasizes people management and personal development promotes change- and innovation management in complex business organizations, and that top leadership plays a crucial role in supporting change and innovation.

Method: semi-structured interview with 10 middle managers in a large Swedish corporation.

Grade: Distinction

Claudio Mares 2021 The relationship between effective team leadership and evolving work models in a small financial services company: A study of Company X.

This research investigated team leadership in a small case study organisation, Company X, a financial services company with fifteen staff, that quickly transitioned from office-based to virtual to hybrid working during the Covid-19 pandemic. The researcher carried out 10 interviews with staff members and also drew on information from two staff surveys. The research found that effective team leaders at Company X kept their teams focused on tasks, they provided them with support to be as effective as possible, and helped, developed, and connected with people

Grade: Distinction

Volha Mitra 2021 Leading an Organisation During the COVID-19 Crisis

This is an exploratory qualitative study that used a semi-structured interviews with 12 employees to enquire into the challenges they faced during the early stages of the COVID-19 crisis, their perceptions of how the organisation reacted to the crisis, and their thoughts on leadership during the crisis. The findings indicate the value placed on collaborative, participative leadership behaviour during the crisis.

Grade: Distinction

Peter Ormerod 2014 The Impact of Vision and Leadership on Classroom Technology Deployments in UK Schools

The research explores possible relationships between leadership style and educational outcomes – including school culture, staff culture, and educational value - in classroom technology projects in the UK. The findings indicate that leadership styles which embody transformational characteristics can bring dramatic additional benefits across multiple outcome measures, as compared to styles which are more managerial in nature.

Method: survey, with 1600 responses.

Grade: Distinction

Alistair Squires 2014 Effective Leadership in a Health Service: A case study of a healthcare organisation that has recently undergone structural change

This study sought to investigate how healthcare leaders in a case study organisation define effective leadership, and also whether or not there was evidence to suggest effective leadership exists in the organisation. The research presents the top five attributes, skills and behaviours as an internally derived definition of effective leadership within the organisation. Five recommendations for improving leadership within the organisation are offered.

Method: a sequential mixed-method approach, with ten semi-structured interviews, followed by a questionnaire returned by 164 managers and leaders.

Grade: Distinction